entrusted me with the responsibility of heading and managing state finances in 2008 when I was virtually one of the junior-most principal secretary level officers in the cadre. She trusted my judgement and opted for the digitally advanced and remarkably prescient Bhamashah programme (which was a precursor of the JAM trinity later) in place of populist programmes like free power, free rations, etc. She called for my services again to head the finance department when she returned to power in 2013. I am thankful to her for the responsibilities she entrusted me with and the freedom she accorded for managing the finance department professionally.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi chose me, in a very unconventional manner, to go to the World Bank as India's executive director while I was still in the service at the level of additional secretary. The experience I gained there of the inner workings of the global financial system, in particular, international developmental financing, was quite extraordinary.

I am thankful to Srimulyani Indrawati and Kristalina Georgieva, two chief executive officers who chaired most of the board meetings for their deft handling of the board. I express my appreciation for the board practice of four minutes' intervention, which equipped me to present my case on any complex policy matter within the time limit and without referring to any notes.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Dr P.K. Mishra brought me to the department of economic affairs as secretary—the place where my understanding and assessment of the Indian economy got more clarified and deepened. I must thank both Prime Minister Modi and Dr Mishra for giving me this extraordinary opportunity to participate in national economic policymaking, budget-making and interacting with world leaders in multilateral fora.

The late Arun Jaitley was quite a remarkable finance minister and human being. His ability to get to the nub of the issues and trust his officers to run the departments was simply extraordinary. This provided me